pitches. Here the wickets were rolled mud. Outfields were bare, dry and bumpy. I had an unprecedented duty to entertain.

The locals sat there, watching the world go by, and knew what they were looking for. ‘Get on with it, Cook,’ ordered one disembodied voice, with an unmistakable lilting accent, when I began studiously. ‘Play some shots, man.’ They loved Ramnaresh Sarwan, a Guyanese of Indian descent who would go on to captain the West Indies during a distinguished sixteen-year international career.

He scored a big hundred, but on the rare occasion he played a false shot the old boys on the boundary would be quick to give him strong advice. ‘What are you doing, man?’ they’d shout. ‘You got to defend, you got to attack.’ We were all too aware the final would be played at the Kensington Oval in Bridgetown, spiritual home of Sobers, Weekes, Hall, Griffith, Garner, Haynes and the rest.

Cricket is suffering in an impatient, time-poor society, but it still straddles boundaries of class and culture. It remains capable of surprising and engaging me, after all these years. Once, on holiday in the Maldives, I was persuaded to play by the hotel staff, who mainly hailed from India, Pakistan and Bangladesh.

The game was their release, on a solitary day off. They were fanatical about it and recognized me the instant I checked in with Alice. Of course I didn’t deserve special treatment, but the waiters ensured speciality sushi was waiting on the lunch table each day. They were soon talking enthusiastically about the match they had planned. It proved to be the favourite day of our break.

It was serious stuff, island against island, played in shorts and bare feet. We took a boat to a nearby atoll, which was no more than fifty yards wide. It had two or three houses at one end, and as we set up the wicket, someone walked across the scrubby outfield with a freshly killed chicken, which was destined to be lunch.

I was worried about hitting the ball into the sea, so theatrically blocked my first few deliveries. The next bloke in just whacked it into the water; fielders dived in to retrieve the ball. It was a day of joy, laughter and perspective. I can’t honestly remember the result of the match, but that’s part of the attraction.

For once, I didn’t have to win.